

between your device and a service, but the service may still be able to read it. End-to-end encryption keeps the service from possessing the keys needed to read message content under normal operation. Neither model automatically hides the account used, the people communicating or the fact that communication occurred.

A private conversation can become identifying through its contents. Mentioning your employer, neighbourhood, timetable or a recent incident may reveal you more reliably than a username. Ask whether the recipient needs each detail.

Match the tool to the threat. A family group does not need the same procedures as a journalist receiving confidential material. Stronger protection brings stricter habits and greater consequences when recovery information is lost.

Configure Signal for less phone-number exposure

Signal provides end-to-end encrypted messages and calls, but an account must still be registered with a phone number. Usernames allow people to begin contact without being given that number. Signal's current privacy settings can also limit who sees the number and who can find the account by searching for it. People who already have the number saved may still associate it with you.

Follow these steps on the latest Signal version:

1. Open Signal Settings > Privacy > Phone Number.
2. Review Who can see my number and select the narrowest option compatible with your contacts.
3. Review Who can find me by my number. Choosing the more restrictive setting means new contacts will need your exact username.
4. Open your profile and create a username that is not reused elsewhere.
5. Share the username, QR code or generated link instead of publishing your number.



6. Test the setup with a trusted person who does not already have your number.
7. Recheck these settings after reinstalling the application or changing devices.

A Signal username is a contact mechanism, not a permanent public handle. It is not displayed in chats in place of the profile name. Treat its QR code or link as contact information rather than posting it everywhere.

Use an original profile name and image appropriate to the identity compartment. Signal does not verify that a displayed profile name belongs to a real-world person. A familiar photograph or biography may reconnect an otherwise private contact route to another account.



Verify the person, not just the encryption

Encryption protects a channel only when you are communicating with the intended person. A scammer using a convincing name and photograph can still receive perfectly encrypted messages.

Every one-to-one Signal conversation has a safety number. For sensitive contacts, compare the number or scan its QR code through a second trusted channel or in person. Marking it as verified causes later changes to require attention before new messages are sent. Signal stresses that the safety number verifies the security of the channel with that contact; it does not independently prove the person's legal identity.

Use this verification routine:

1. Establish contact through a channel already trusted.
2. Open the person's Signal profile and select View Safety Number.
3. Scan the QR code in person, use automatic verification where available, or compare the number through another authenticated channel.